

# "We will dismantle much of governmental control"

*Kapil Sibal, the new Union minister for human resources development, spoke at length to INDIA TODAY Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA about his plans to revamp the education sector. Excerpts:*

**Q. To end the multiplicity of organisations controlling higher education, there are recommendations to have an over-arching independent regulatory authority. Would you implement them?**

**A.** We do need a structural change. The findings of the Yashpal Committee and that of the National Knowledge Commission with regard to higher education will be implemented. Those are pivotal to any structural changes that we need to make in the higher education system.

**Q. Do you think what was done in 1991 to liberalise the economy should now come to the education sector?**

**A.** Yes. What Manmohan Singh did to the economy in 1991, must be done to the education sector in 2009. Once we are able to increase the Gross Enrolment Ratio of people going in for graduation and beyond from the current 11 per cent to 20-25 per cent, then we have a sufficient stock of people to

choose from, then you are talking of better quality graduates and better outputs. The prime minister is extremely keen that these are areas where the Government must proactively move forward. I don't think that is a problem. I think the problem is institutional, structural and too much governmental control which we will try and dismantle.

**Q. One of the reasons is the problem of high cut-offs because of the shortage of good colleges. How can that be changed?**

**A.** There is a simple way to it. If you have an accreditation system, which allows a professional agency to accredit schools and has entry-barriers which are strict, then alone can people set up colleges. Anybody who passes the entry barrier should be allowed to set up a college. Why should it be limited to A, B or C. Once you do that, for instance, you can prescribe things like—you need this kind of experience, you need this amount of finance guaranteed and for student-teacher this should be the size of the physical assets. Anybody who passes that test should be allowed to set up a college. If I make the structural changes that I am talking about, you will not have a problem as to why should a person not set

up a college? Why should somebody not be able to set up a university?

**Q. Would that include permitting foreign universities to set up shop in the country?**

**A.** Every year 60,000 students go out of India and \$7 billion is the cost to the exchequer. Why shouldn't we have Harvard-like institutions here? Why should we not have Princeton, Yale, Oxford, Cambridge—either indigenous or their presence here? What prevents us as long as we make sure that fly-by-night operators do not come in and the regulatory procedures are in place?

**Q. The fee structure in colleges is low for liberal arts compared to school education but can be very high for professional courses in private colleges.**

**A.** Once these entry barriers are passed, then a final certificate—that everything has been complied with—should be given. And then you compete in the market like the rest. Also there is the issue of inclusion. How does a child who belongs to the underprivileged classes make an entry into a college if the fee structure is completely open? The problem is that if you control fee then the quality goes down. If you don't control fee then you can't be inclusive. Equity is

at the heart of a good education system. We don't have equity; we don't have quality education in a country like India. You need an education development and finance corporation to give a loan to every child to enter college. That takes care of the college fee as well as meets the need of inclusion, allows competition, and frees the system from government control. Access, equity and quality are the three aims I am going to stress while revamping the education system.



**"WHY SHOULDN'T WE HAVE INSTITUTIONS LIKE YALE and Oxford, as long as we can keep fly-by-night operators out."**